

Inventing is still recognized as the default get-rich-quick method out there, and yes, it is alive and well. However, don't be fooled. Inventing isn't really about inventing the vehicle, the telephone, or the goofy Segway—the core activity of inventors is just taking something and improving or modifying it. Take something old and stale and make it better. Take an underexposed product, make it your own, and reintroduce it to the world. Take something unconventional and make it conventional.

On TV, I watched a successful entrepreneur interview in which the inventor simply repackaged vodka from boring old clear bottles to colorful bottles with razzle-dazzle. In fact, for my birthday I received a skull-shaped bottle of vodka. Vodka has been around for centuries, yet an entrepreneur took a stale product and added an element of uniqueness and differentiation. Sometimes it's that simple.

My favorite example is the Snuggie, an oversized mass-marketed blanket with arms. The product concept has been around for years, but they took the concept, repackaged it, remarketed it, and wham, 40 million sold later, they had a blockbuster.

Innovation is a dual challenged process: *manufacture* and *distribution*. Inventing a product that solves a need is half the battle; the other half is getting your invention into the hands of millions, which involves a variety of distribution channels: infomercial (sell via mass media), retail (sell to distributors and wholesalers), and direct marketing (sell via print media, postal mail, Internet).

For example, when I wrote this book, I was the means of manufacture. I wrote it, put it together, edited it, and had it physically published. I manufactured it. I engaged in innovation. However, like all innovation roads, manufacture is one tiny battle in a larger war. Distribution is where the war is won. A great product is worthless if it doesn't get into the hands of people, and that requires distribution. For my book, I will need to leverage Amazon (a distribution system), book distributors (wholesalers), and the Internet (another distribution system) if I am to succeed.

Yes, your product invention can be something you invent yet is manufactured in China, or an e-book you write in a weekend. Innovation—from books to products—is Fastlane. Have you ever wondered why people sell get-rich-quick books and yet the content is just regurgitated blather from 30 prior books? The authors know that authoring is a potent Fastlane.

The challenge of any authoring Fastlane is never the book or the words themselves. Some of the greatest books in the world go unread, while the mediocre stuff sells millions. The difference lies in marketing, public relations, and just good old-fashioned business know-how. *Writing a book is not a business; selling the book is.* If I'm obsessively intent on selling this book to millions, I have to manufacture, then distribute. I have to sell, market, promote, appear, speak, interview, and write; I have to invest in the business of distribution. To leverage the Fastlane wealth